

CASE STUDY

Onboarding a Visual Artist

Building financial infrastructure for a creative-economy business

Client	Visual artist (relief printmaker) — name anonymized
Business Type	Sole proprietor, creative-economy service/product hybrid
Engagement Stage	Onboarding complete; first quarterly review scheduled
Purpose of Case Study	Demonstrate client-onboarding methodology and strategic thinking

A note on scope

This case study documents the diagnostic and planning phase of a client engagement. Results will be measured at the first quarterly review. The purpose here is to demonstrate the framework used to take a creative-economy business from unstructured revenue and informal financial decision-making to a clear 12-month operating plan with measurable KPIs.

Executive Summary

The client is a full-time working artist producing relief prints and carved woodwork, selling through galleries, direct commissions, residencies, and grants. Revenue in the prior year was generated primarily through fellowships, with direct sales as an underdeveloped channel. The client arrived with strong artistic output, active grant-writing discipline, and no unified financial infrastructure.

The onboarding engagement produced three deliverables: (1) a business-structure recommendation separating personal and business finances, (2) a revenue model anchored to a \$10K monthly target with unit economics by product tier, and (3) a strategic focus framework ("Five Ones") to concentrate marketing and product effort in year one. KPIs and a quarterly check-in cadence were established before the client began execution.

Client Goals (Stated)

- **Income:** \$60K gross annual revenue from art; stretch goal of \$10K/month
- **Structure:** Separate business banking; cleaner bookkeeping; avoid tax surprises
- **Visibility:** Increase audience without relying on Instagram
- **Lifestyle:** Full-time artistry supported by residencies and international travel

Diagnostic Summary

- **Revenue concentration risk:** Fellowships were the largest revenue source in the prior year, but are non-recurring and competitive.
- **Pricing opacity:** A tiered pricing structure existed informally but was not connected to unit economics or production capacity.
- **Financial commingling:** No separate business checking account; business expenses, revenue, and personal spending ran through one account.
- **Channel uncertainty:** Client expressed a desire to leave Instagram but had no alternative audience channel operational.
- **Conversion gap:** Website was identified as underperforming as a sales channel and did not reflect the brand.

The Onboarding Framework

My onboarding process moves a client from initial fit assessment to a quarterly operating plan in four phases. Each phase has a clear purpose, a defined output, and produces artifacts the client keeps regardless of whether they continue the engagement.

Phase	Purpose	Key Activities	Output
1. Fit & Scope	Confirm mutual fit, set expectations, scope engagement	Screening conversation, engagement terms, cadence agreement	Signed scope; communication rhythm
2. Discovery	Understand the business and the owner's relationship to it	Structured interview, vision + frustration surfacing	Client profile; stated goals and constraints
3. Data Intake	Gather the financial reality behind the narrative	12-month revenue, expenses, debt, pricing, tools audit	Baseline data set; gap list
4. Plan & KPIs	Translate diagnosis into action and measurement	Timeline, priority stack, KPI definition, cadence	90-day plan; KPI dashboard; quarterly check-in scheduled

Phase 1 — Fit & Scope

Before I ask a client about their finances, I need to know whether I can actually help them and whether they are ready to do the work. This phase is short but non-negotiable.

What I assess

- Whether the client's challenges are ones I can meaningfully address
- Whether the client has the capacity (time, emotional bandwidth, financial runway) to act on advice
- Whether expectations about pace, communication, and outcomes are aligned

Outcome for this client

The client was a strong fit: actively running a business, clear about where they felt stuck, and asking specifically for structural help rather than tactical fixes. We agreed on a quarterly check-in cadence with asynchronous support between meetings.

Phase 2 — Discovery

The discovery conversation is the most important hour of the engagement. It is not a data intake; it is a structured interview designed to surface how the owner thinks about their business, where the friction lives, and what they actually want.

Core questions I ask every client

- How do you make money? Walk me through every revenue stream.
- How much money did you make in the last 12 months?
- How are you currently making financial decisions?
- What is the most confusing or frustrating part of your business right now?
- If you had a magic wand and could change one thing, what would it be?
- How much do you pay yourself, and how do you calculate that?
- What tools or processes do you use to track your numbers?
- How often are you willing to manage your numbers as part of running the business?
- If we were meeting a year from now and you felt completely in control of your business finances, what would have changed?

What I heard from this client

Client's own words (paraphrased from interview)

On the vision: Full-time artistry integrated into community — more spaciousness, healing, and joy. International residencies (Penland, McDowell, Anderson Ranch, Vermont Studio Center) as a regular rhythm, not a once-in-a-career event.

On the friction: Conversion is a challenge. Website does not feel like a home for the work. Instagram drains energy without producing sales. Pricing needs structure.

On the business model: Preference for direct sales over gallery commission splits. Selective about commissions. Revenue in the prior year leaned heavily on fellowships and grants (~20 grant applications per month).

Phase 3 — Data Intake

Before any planning, I collect the actual numbers. This phase often reveals that the stated problem is not the real problem.

Baseline data collected

Category	Client's Baseline
Revenue streams (prior year)	Fellowships (largest), direct sales, gallery shows, commissions, grants
Revenue target	\$60K/year minimum; \$10K/month stretch goal
Pricing tiers	\$25 community prints / \$250–\$350 standard prints / ~\$3K one-off wood carvings (5/year)
Fixed costs	Studio rent \$625/mo; printmaking studio \$100/mo; software ~\$70/mo
Variable costs per edition	\$200 paper (25 sheets Japanese), \$60 ink (2 cans), ~20 hours labor per 20-print edition
Banking structure	Single personal account; no EIN, no LLC, no separate business checking
Bookkeeping	Informal; no bookkeeping software in use
Other exhibitions	3–4 gallery shows/year; Hapeville Depot Museum residency 1–2x/year

Phase 4 — Plan & KPIs

This is where discovery and data become a plan. For this client, I organized the plan around three workstreams: infrastructure, revenue model, and strategic focus.

Workstream 1: Financial infrastructure

The first priority was separating business and personal finances. This is foundational: without it, none of the later work (tax planning, profitability analysis, pricing decisions) is trustworthy.

- **Open business checking:** All revenue deposited here; all business expenses paid from here. Built-in bookkeeping makes taxes and analytics cleaner.
- **Open business savings with allocation rules:** 24% tax reserve, 26% marketing and travel, 50% owner distribution.
- **Obtain EIN:** Required for a true business account and to establish business credit later.
- **LLC (optional, recommended):** Liability shield given the growing commission and gallery volume; can be formed after banking is in place.
- **Implement bookkeeping software:** Built-in business account bookkeeping recommended; streamlines banking and account processes and creates clean account separation.
- **Mileage tracker app:** Studio, gallery, and residency travel are deductible and should continue to be tracked.

Workstream 2: Revenue model

Goal: \$10K/month. The model below breaks that into product-tier unit economics so the client can see exactly what each channel must produce.

Product Tier	Unit Price	Monthly Volume	Monthly Revenue
Wood carvings	\$3,000	0.5 (1 every 2 months)	\$1,500
Standard prints	\$675 avg	8	\$5,400
Community prints	\$25	124	\$3,100
Target total	—	—	\$10,000

Strategic observation

Community prints at \$25 produce the highest unit volume but the lowest margin per hour of artist time. The model is viable only if community-print production is systematized (larger edition runs, pre-printing, efficient fulfillment). This became a focus area for year one.

Workstream 3: Strategic focus — The Five Ones

A common failure mode for creative-economy businesses is trying every channel and every audience at once. I introduced the "Five Ones" framework: commit to one audience, one channel, one message, one product category, and one year. This concentrates effort where it is most likely to compound.

The Five Ones	Client's Commitment
One audience	Younger collectors (Gen Z and Millennials, 30–50) — underserved by traditional art market; drawn to handmade work, darker imagery, individual artists, and accessible price points
One product	Black and white relief prints at accessible-to-mid tier (\$250–\$1,200)
One channel	Substack (Notes + monthly posts) for audience; website for conversion. Explicitly NOT Instagram.
One message	Handmade, original relief prints accessible to collectors building their first serious collection
One year	Twelve-month commitment before reassessing channel or audience

The "art star vs. art business" decision

A key strategic clarification in onboarding: is the client building toward being an "art star" (reliant on contacts, appearances, and audience-building) or an "art business" (reliant on inventory, systems, and distribution)? These require different investments and produce different kinds of revenue. The client leaned toward the art-business model — a decision that then anchored every recommendation below.

Deliverables Left With the Client

At the close of onboarding, the client has a set of concrete artifacts — not just advice.

- **Financial setup checklist:** Bank accounts, EIN, LLC decision, bookkeeping software, mileage app — with order of operations.
- **\$10K/month revenue model:** Unit economics by product tier; clear volume targets per channel.
- **Five Ones strategic focus:** Audience, product, channel, message, time horizon — all committed in writing.
- **90-day priority stack:** Ordered list of what to do first, second, third — protects against the overwhelm of doing everything at once.
- **KPI dashboard (Q1):** Specific numbers to track before our next meeting.

KPIs and Quarterly Check-In Structure

A plan without measurement is a wish. I set specific, trackable KPIs at the close of onboarding, along with a quarterly rhythm for reviewing them.

KPI	Why it matters	Q1 target
Business accounts operational	Foundation for every subsequent financial decision	Checking, savings, EIN complete
Monthly revenue (trailing)	Primary scoreboard; tied to \$10K/mo stretch goal	Ramping toward \$3K+ by Q1 end
Substack subscribers	The one channel; leading indicator of direct-sale pipeline	Baseline + net growth reported
Prints produced / sold	Capacity and fulfillment reality check against the model	At least one systematized edition run completed
Grant application efficiency	Preserves the prior year's strongest revenue source	Streamline to ~5/month cadence

Quarterly check-in agenda (established at onboarding)

- KPI review: actual vs. target, with explanation of variances
- Cash flow and P&L review (once bookkeeping is live)
- Priority stack for the next 90 days
- One strategic question the client wants me to think about before our next call

Reflection on the Engagement

This onboarding illustrates the approach I bring to every client engagement: move from narrative to numbers to plan, in that order. The client came in with a creative practice and a set of frustrations. They left onboarding with a business structure, a revenue model tied to specific unit economics, a strategic focus that concentrates effort rather than scattering it, and a measurement rhythm that makes progress visible.

Results from this engagement will be reported after the first quarterly review.

What this case study demonstrates

- A repeatable four-phase onboarding framework (Fit → Discovery → Data → Plan)
- The ability to translate a creative-economy business into clear unit economics
- Strategic discipline — recommending focus over expansion
- An output-oriented engagement style: every phase ends with a concrete artifact the client keeps
- KPI and cadence discipline from day one

— End of case study —